death

&

transfiguration

(a reimagining of Debussy)

(in two parts)

PART 1: INTRODUCTION

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"I will try to see, through the works, the multiple movements that gave birth to them and what they contain of inner life; isn't that otherwise more interesting than the game of dismantling them like curious watches?"

– CLAUDE DEBUSSY

i. introduction

A recurring aspect of scholarship on the music of Debussy is the humility with which analysts approach the formal and harmonic content of his later works. Often deemed an "intuitive" composer, Debussy is described as "resistant" to formalized analysis. Indeed, he himself was notably adversarial toward ideas of authority and definitive interpretation. In an article for La Revue Blanche (April 1901), Debussy remarked:

We are going to witness the usual exercises on the different ways of conducting Beethoven's symphonies; some will "hurry," others will "slow down"… Serious and informed persons will declare that such and such conductor possesses the true movement… Where did these persons get such assurance, from the Beyond? …That would greatly surprise me coming from Beethoven."

Debussy was similarly ambivalent towards the validity of analysis. If the composer is, indeed, a voice of individual intuition, should the theorist, then, be free to "intuit" meanings and strategies to derive from his music?

The writer here answers affirmatively: *Des pas sur la neige* is a work of depth and ambiguity in contradiction to its short duration, thematic sparsity, and formal simplicity. We are invited not only to share in its methods of execution, but also to hybridize our analytical approaches and– in the spirit of intuition, blend and adjust formal frameworks. Naturally, there is a difficult balance to come by: if a framework can be nudged here and fudged there, it isn't long before we are extrapolating fugues out of *Die schöne Müllerin* and atonality from *Johannespassion*. It's important, then, that a fidelity be maintained to coherence and continuity. For example, using pitch class sets to demarcate formal structure should correspondingly be applied melodic and harmonic content, rather than mixing modal/scalar analysis and functional harmony– whenever possible. Preferable, too, is whether an analytic modality applies to music other than the piece at hand.

ii. in footprints : a prelude

Whether looking through the first book of *Preludes*, the entire set of twenty-four, or the whole of the Debussy's instrumental works, *Des pas sur la neige* is a rare standout. There is a perceptible sentimentality to the work, one of melancholic profundity. It features a combination of sparseness and repetition that isn't found in any other works in his oeuvre; interestingly, it is

one of only very few pieces, excluding dramatic and vocal works (an admittedly large portion of the total),

that illustrates a *human* subject:

3 Scènes au crépuscule
Andante cantabile
Ballade slave
Berceuse héroïque
Cello Sonata
Children's Corner ✸
Danses
- Danse sacrée
- Danse profane

Divertissement
D'un cahier d'esquisses
Élégie
En blanc et noir
Estampes
- Pagodes
- La soirée dans Grenade
- Jardins sous la pluie

Étude retrouvée
Études
- Pour les cinq doigts
- Pour les tierces
- Pour les quartes
- Pour les sixtes
- Pour les octaves
- Pour les huit doigts
- Pour les degrés chromatiques
- Pour les agréments
- Pour les notes répétées
- Pour les sonorités
- Pour les arpèges
- Pour les accords

Fantaisie
Fragment for Piano
Hommage à Joseph Haydn
Images
- Gigues
- Ibéria
- Rondes du printemps

Images oubliées
- Lent (mélancolique et doux)
- Souvenir du Louvre
- Quelques aspects…

Images, Set 1
- Reflets dans l'eau
- Hommage à Rameau
- Mouvement

Images, Set 2
- Cloches à travers les feuilles
- Et la lune descend sur la temple
- Poisson d'or

Intermède
Intermezzo
La Mer
La plus que lente
Les soirs illuminés par l'ardeur du charbon
L'Isle Joyeuse
Lindaraja ✸
Marche écossaise sur un thème
Masques
Mazurka
Morceau de Concours
Nocturne
Nocturne et Scherzo
Nocturnes
- Nuages
- Fêtes
- Sirènes

Petite pièce
Petite suite
- En bateau
- Cortège
- Menuet
- Ballet

Pièce pour le Vêtement du blessé
Pièce pour piano
Pour le piano
- Prélude
- Sarabande
- Toccata

Prélude à l'après-midi d'un faune
Preludes
- Book I
  - Danseuses de Delphes
  - Voiles
  - Le vent dans la plaine
  - Les sons et les parfums tournent
  - Les collines d'Anacapri
  - Des pas sur la neige ✸
  - Ce qu'a vu le vent d'ouest
  - La fille aux cheveux de lin ✸
  - La sérénade interrompue
  - La cathédrale engloutie
  - La danse de Puck
  - Minstrels ✸

Preludes
- Book II
  - Brouillards
  - Feuilles mortes
  - La puerta del Vino
  - Les fées sont d'exquises
  - Bruyères
  - Général Lavine – eccentric ✸
  - La terrasse des audiences
  - Ondine
  - Hommage à S. Pickwick Esq. ✸
  - Canope
  - Les tierces alternées
  - Feux d'artifice

Rêverie
Rhapsody
Rhapsody for Orchestra and Saxophone
Six épigraphes antiques
- Pour invoquer Pan
- Pour un tombeau sans nom
- Pour que la nuit soit propice
- Pour la danseuse aux crotales ✸
- Pour l'égyptienne ✸
- Pour remercier la pluie au matin

Sonata for Harp, Flute, and Viola
String Quartet in G minor
Suite bergamasque
- Prélude
- Menuet
- Clair de Lune
- Passepied

Suite for Orchestra
- Fête
- Ballet
- Rêve
- Bacchanale

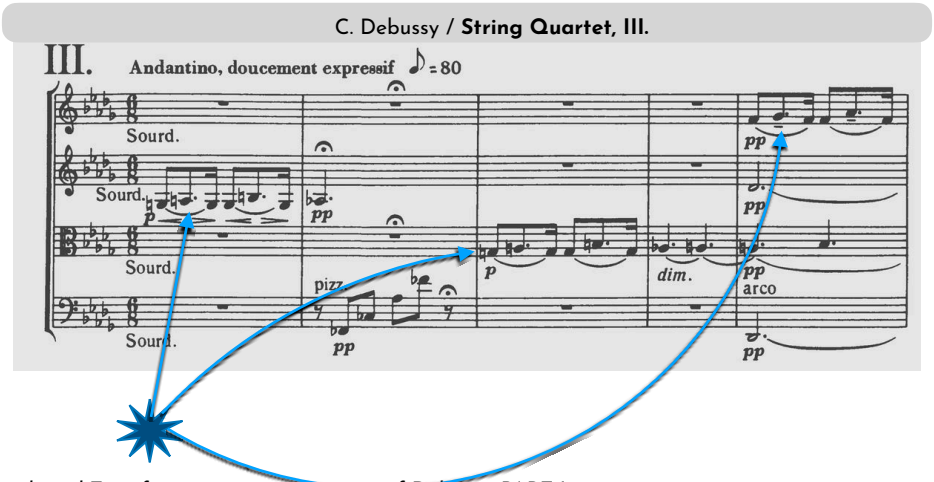
Syrinx
Tarantelle styrienne
The Little Negro ✸
Two Arabesques
Valse romantique
Violin Sonata

While other preludes depict winds, fairies, sails, and statues, *Des pas sur la neige* evokes footprints—fragile, disembodied, yet deeply personal relics. Footprints, as a symbolic subject, are unassuming at first glance, yet they are impressions from and suggestions of the past.

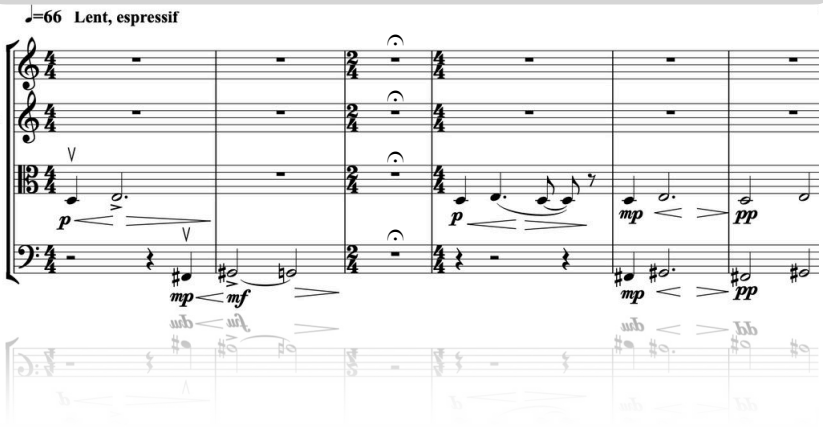
The piece is also marked in its sentimentality, which is one of austerity and melancholy. It is slightly remitting, but not conquering, of the incessant sadness embodied in its central motive. That motive, a melodic ascent of two steps (whole, and then half) presented as an idea/answer (or call/response) by way of rhythmic displacement, is the piece's *idée fixe*. Unchanging until its very last statement, where it remains fixed on the same pitch, this theme does not rise to the status of a melody: by restricting it to the space of a minor third, staggering its presentation via two separated ascensions, Debussy has given the piece its titular image, and crafted it for a singularly desolate, monotonous, even haunting character.



This material may be recalling another theme from one one of the composer's most sentimentally tragic movements, and can be seen with similar function in the works of other composers, as well:



A. Goodhart / **String Quartet**



D. Shostakovich, **Piano Quintet, ii.**



At its outset, Debussy writes an additional programmatic note that may hint at further depth: "*ce rythme doit avoir la valeur sonore d'un fond de paysage triste et glacé*" (*The rhythm must have the sound of a sad and frozen landscape*). There is a subtle tension between title and direction here; The softness of snow, as reflected in his popular work *The Snow is Dancing*, is not apparent in the austere bleakness of the music. The subject of the title's program, too, has an illusive ambiguity to it: the prints are proxy to their bodies, gone from the scene, and thus the scene itself is curious. Why is it with such a sadness that we look on it?

With these many clever and curious ambiguities or contradictions, Debussy is indicating a depth and gravity of *Des pas sur la neige* that is quite larger than the imagery it is assigned. It is a psychological meditation, integrating the mind framed in past, present, and perhaps future. I invite musicians and audiences to consider that for us and for the composer, the piece is no painted landscape; rather, that it is transcending time, space, and corporeality. Perhaps reflecting loss, suggesting the past, depicting the present and looking to the future: this is the context that becomes the "prelude" to its own analysis: what footsteps are left in this work, and how can we better understand it by looking from beneath, above, forward, and backward?

The uniqueness demonstrable in the piece's subject and sentimentality extends to many aspects of its musical material. What this amounts to is a kind of existential mourning, where the quiet and relentless echo of pain underlies all experience, becoming the prism through which all phenomena are interpreted. By its unique sonic and programmatic profile, the author sees continual potential in portraying the piece in this temporally unrooted or even inverted.

iii. many prints : many paths

Deserving more consideration (than can be allowed here) is this seemingly unique quality to Debussy's music, that it be so frequently a roadblock (or springboard) in the application and development of frameworks. When dealing with musical works as removed from the common practice period as, for example, *The Dream of Jacob, Turangalîla, Music for Strings, Percussion, and Celesta*–? Of course: pitch class sets, generative theory, etc.! But that is not this prelude.

Important to remember is that Debussy's training is born more strongly from the Renaissance tradition of polyphony than the Common Practice period. So it doesn't surprise that, even with the preponderance of tritone and pianistically voiced sonorities, *Des pas sur la neige* fits easily into the shape of a contrapuntal work. Of course, this would not be appropriate material, but it could easily be fashioned for organ. Debussy did not include the work in the selections chosen for his arrangement in *Douze pièces pour l'orgue grande,* which is perhaps unfortunate. Still, imagining what that would look like is illuminating for analyst and player in that it highlights the linear and deliberately voiced nature of its parts (which helps to explain their elusiveness in harmonic analysis):

C. Debussy / *Des pas sur la neige*, "open score"



To the author, this score looks readily familiar, like some passacaglia for trio with obbligato basso e continuo, deeply grave praeludium or variational ricercar. This *open score* view of the prelude has a lot to say about its inner workings, and it can also help the player's connection to the material; for example, the linear

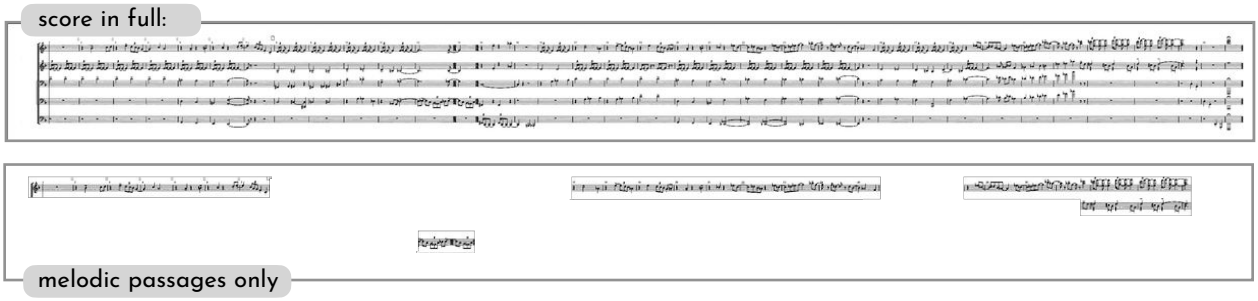
A. Gabrieli / Ricercar del duodecimo tuono



view can help one empathize with the transience of certain pitches– how they waft into the texture for only a subphrase or so. One can imagine the zealous choral director who was enthralled by the idea of the arrangement (and, likely, of the superhuman tessituras at their disposal), but a bit chafed for time, instructing the low voices:

"We're short on tenors this weekend, so, sing their line and divide at bar five. Erm, basses: this isn't really so difficult, just a perfect fifth with delusions of grandeur… yes, you can sing that pickup D down the octave…"

The open view also makes the limited role of melody in the piece startlingly clear. Compare, as below, the amount of part writing which is, essentially, neighbor tones/appoggiaturas/and other slight or unmemorable and/or texturally immersed linearities vs. conventionally (and, without needing to be fixated on outdated ideas thereof) *melodic* passages:



Thus, the performer is going to, very likely, find much joy and nuance in both the differentiation of these parts and the melodicization of material that is, by its nature, accompanimental. What we see in the comparison above is also a rendering of the formal structure to the prelude. After all, what is its form? In considering this, we are confronted with two vexations:

1. The piece is not functionally harmonic, and is dutifully fixed on its central pitch (D) by way of the motive without break.

2. There is a paucity of melodic material.

However, it truly is made simpler by taking this larger view. The regular simple binary grouping of the simple miniature simple binary that *is* the motive lulls the listener into a state of timelessness. The performer may well find themselves in the same place when searching for structural cleavages. The presence or absence of a melodic figure, however, makes this abundantly clear:



Renaissance polyphony will continue to prove a viable companion to the analyst and performer, in simple matters of identifying active forces and their transformations, such as the motivic structure and its interchange through voices, as well as deeper matters that linger throughout the peripheries of this work, its image, its sound world, and––perhaps, indeed–– any analysis of Debussy. With Debussy working in a manner that is well received when looking backward, further than the standard bearer's of romanticism and their models, what can be said of what Debussy looks *forward* to?

There, we will find a bird's eye view of the footprints themselves, and, the author hopes, be *transfigured* by the *death* it reveals.

END OF PART 1